

Chapter 163-1

This decision was actually quite difficult.

Especially at a moment like this.

In economics, there's a term called "sunk cost."

It refers to the time, money, energy, and other costs previously invested in something, but which are irrelevant to current and future decisions.

Clearly, the sunk cost of this decision was too high.

When Liang Shi had made that decision before, she had done so with the determination of burning her boats¹.

The pain was real, the sorrow was real, even the separation was real.

She had forced herself not to contact Xu Qingzhu, not to learn any news about her, not to see her even once.

As long as they got through this period, it would be fine.

They just needed to sign that divorce agreement.

Then they could exploit the bug in this world's operating rules.

At that point, it wouldn't matter how Xu Qingzhu punished her.

As long as Xu Qingzhu stopped having those nightmares, as long as she didn't become unlike herself.

But now, after seeing her just once, Liang Shi's defenses had crumbled.

Since it was causing Xu Qingzhu pain and sorrow either way, they might as well try to face it together.

If it really was as Xu Qingzhu said, perhaps they needed to love each other as if every day were the last day of their lives.

Only then would there probably be no regrets.

If there truly were regrets, it should be regretting not having met in another, better place.

Rather than like this—regretting not having loved.

Regretting having loved yet still parting.

But embracing Xu Qingzhu now, making promises, meant that all the steps Liang Shi had taken before were wasted.

They had only suffered for nothing.

But there's another saying in economics: "Sunk costs are not costs."

When Liang Shi held Xu Qingzhu, Xu Qingzhu's entire body was trembling—trembling continuously even while being held.

Xu Qingzhu buried herself in Liang Shi's shoulder and sobbed uncontrollably, tears soaking through her clothes.

Liang Shi's tears fell too.

By the end, both had cried themselves voiceless.

When their eyes met again, Liang Shi reached out and gently wiped away Xu Qingzhu's tears, saying with heartache: "Your eyes are so red. Stop crying."

Xu Qingzhu choked out: "I don't want to either, but I can't control it."

It wasn't like this before—it had just started these past few days.

Once she started crying, it was hard to stop.

Unless she cried herself to sleep.

There were even several times when she cried until her heart hurt so much she needed to pound her chest with her fist. Crying until she couldn't speak was a minor thing—once she nearly couldn't catch her breath, and she specifically went to see a doctor.

The doctor's response was that her pregnancy symptoms were quite pronounced. Her hormones were being secreted too vigorously, combined with emotional stagnation, leading to low mood and sensitivity, increased crying, and being unable to stop once she started.

It would get somewhat better later, but the first three or four months would be tough.

The doctor repeatedly reminded her not to have extreme emotional swings, to do some yoga suitable for pregnant women, listen to soft music, and regulate her mood.

But today she couldn't hold back, and once she started crying, she couldn't stop.

Liang Shi could only stroke her back to soothe her. "I'm sorry, it's all my fault."

Xu Qingzhu sniffled, feeling slightly better.

"I shouldn't have made decisions on my own, thinking I was being good to you." Liang Shi said, "I've always been timid, I..."

She paused, but the words that followed still didn't come out.

If she hadn't seen Xu Qingzhu today, she wouldn't have believed it either.

Liang Shi knew Xu Qingzhu liked her—one could even say loved her.

But Liang Shi didn't think anyone would love her this much, so much that they would willingly die alongside her tomorrow.

Liang Shi didn't think she was such a great person.

Her face was just average. Xu Qingzhu had seen so many beautiful people; her face wasn't anything special.

As for personality, someone in Xu Qingzhu's position could have any personality type she wanted.

Liang Shi didn't think she was special or unique. She had even thought about what she would do if Xu Qingzhu fell for someone else.

In a way, she was actually more rational than Xu Qingzhu.

In this relationship, she wasn't as steadfast as Xu Qingzhu.

Without Xu Qingzhu, she could still have friendship, have a career, do things she loved, see scenery she wanted to see.

Probably because from the very beginning, she had never claimed Xu Qingzhu as her own.

In her subconscious, Xu Qingzhu would meet someone who shared her aspirations.

She was merely a passerby in Xu Qingzhu's life.

In Xu Qingzhu's long life, she could only accompany her for one leg of the journey.

That one leg would be enough for her to reminisce about for half her life.

Perhaps if she was lucky enough, she could find someone else to love mutually.

This unforgettable first love would remain in her memories.

Or perhaps, like her previous life, she would never have lasting luck.

And she would live the rest of her days on memories alone.

In any case, Xu Qingzhu was not her first choice.

Rather than saying that, it would be more accurate to say that love had never been her first choice.

Footnotes:

¹ **Burning her boats (破釜沉舟):** A Chinese idiom literally meaning "break the cauldrons and sink the boats." It originates from a historical battle where a general ordered his troops to destroy their cooking pots and boats after crossing a river, leaving no option for retreat. It means to commit fully to something with no way back, similar to "burning bridges" but with the connotation of desperate determination.